

Western Deserts



THE STONY DESERTS OF NORTH AMERICA cover large areas of the southwestern United States and northern Mexico. The largest is the Great Basin, which is sandwiched between two ranges of mountains—the Rockies to the east and the Sierras to the west. To the south, the Great Basin merges with the Mojave Desert. Between the two lies Death Valley, one of the hottest places on Earth. South of the Mojave is the Sonoran Desert, which is famous for its giant saguaro cacti.

The desert is a harsh environment, but many animals survive there, making the most of the little moisture available. Some survive without drinking at all. Many stay in burrows during the day, emerging only at night when the air is cooler and damper.

Antenna ears

The kit fox is the smallest fox in North America. It comes out at night to hunt, using its huge ears as antennae to track down its prey, which is mainly kangaroo rats, prairie dogs, and rabbits. The fox is able to run very swiftly to overtake and seize them before they disappear down their burrows.



Kit fox (*Vulpes macrotis*)
Body length: up to 21 in (53.5 cm)
Tail: up to 13 in (34 cm)

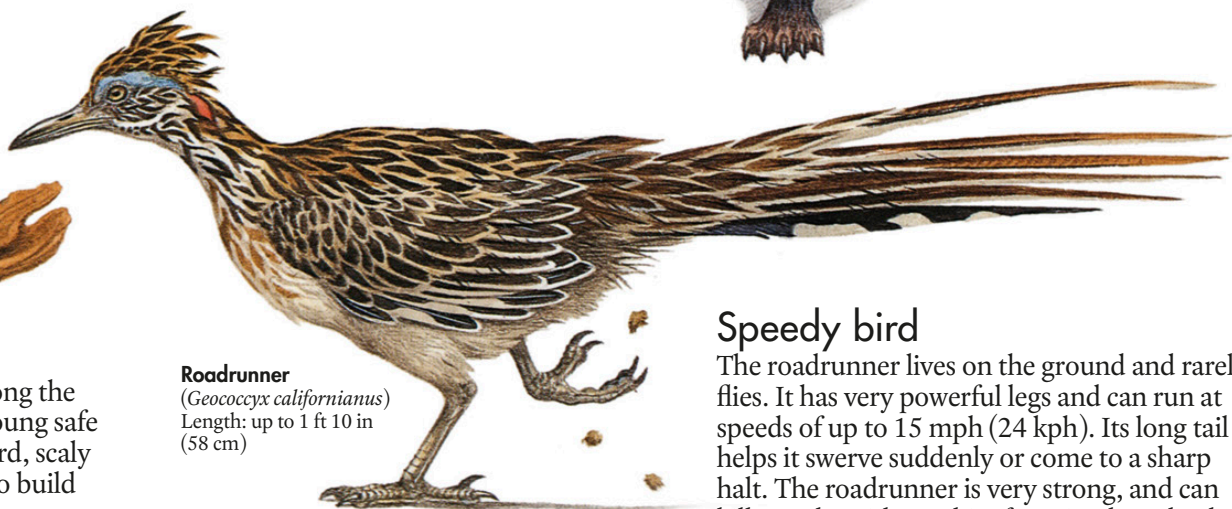
Cactus wren
(*Campylorhynchus brunneicapillus*)
Length: up to 7.5 in (19 cm)



Spiny fortress

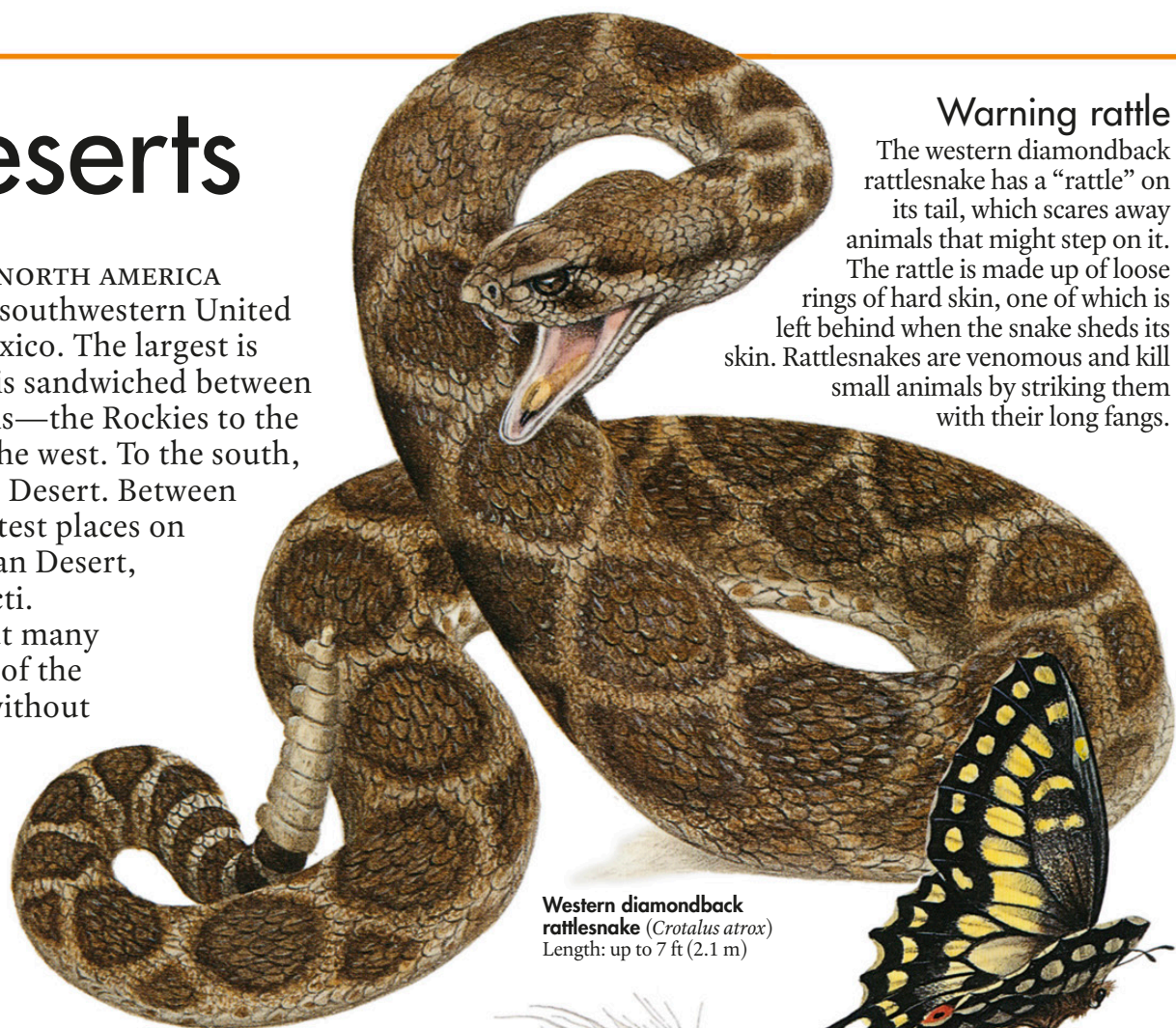
The cactus wren builds a large, domed nest among the spines of a cactus or a thorny bush to keep its young safe from enemies. The bird's tough feathers and hard, scaly legs protect it from scratches. The wren may also build extra nests to roost in during the winter.

Roadrunner
(*Geococcyx californianus*)
Length: up to 1 ft 10 in (58 cm)



Speedy bird

The roadrunner lives on the ground and rarely flies. It has very powerful legs and can run at speeds of up to 15 mph (24 kph). Its long tail helps it swerve suddenly or come to a sharp halt. The roadrunner is very strong, and can kill a snake with one bite from its sharp beak.



Western diamondback rattlesnake (*Crotalus atrox*)
Length: up to 7 ft (2.1 m)

Warning rattle
The western diamondback rattlesnake has a "rattle" on its tail, which scares away animals that might step on it. The rattle is made up of loose rings of hard skin, one of which is left behind when the snake sheds its skin. Rattlesnakes are venomous and kill small animals by striking them with their long fangs.



Desert swallowtail
(*Papilio polyxenes coloro*)
Wingspan: up to 3.5 in (9 cm)

Trailing tails

The desert swallowtail butterfly is named after the long, trailing tails on its back wings, which resemble a swallow's tail. It lives in the mountain canyons of the desert, and only breeds after it rains. The caterpillars of this butterfly give off a foul smell if they are disturbed. This helps frighten off enemies.



Western spotted skunk
(*Spilogale gracilis*)
Body length: up to 14.5 in (37 cm)
Tail: up to 8 in (21 cm)

Smelly defense

A spotted skunk protects itself from its enemies by spraying them with a foul-smelling liquid. This comes from scent glands under its tail. The skunk can hit a target accurately from 3.6 m (12 ft) away. Before it sprays, the skunk stands on its hands to display its striking black and white fur as a warning. The skunk comes out mainly at night to hunt for small animals, eggs, insects, and fruit.